

WHAT IS THE POINT OF SLEEP?

We're always being told that we only live once and to make the most of it. Considering sleep takes up one third of our lives, is it better to forgo it altogether and stay awake so that we can do more? Unfortunately not. Sleep gives the body time to rest and repair while the brain stores the day's experiences. People who are deprived of sleep often suffer from extreme fatigue, headaches, confusion, and even hallucinations. That's why you should stay a sleepyhead!

TIME FOR BED



AVERAGE SLEEP

Before the light bulb was invented in the 1800s, adults slept an average of ten hours every night. The amount of sleep required decreases as people age. Young children need about 16 hours per night, schoolchildren need ten, adults need seven, and the elderly need fewer than six. Woken by crying, new parents each lose up to 750 hours of sleep in the first year of their baby's life.



EARLY BIRDS AND NIGHT OWLS

Those people with a short body clock are early birds who spring out of bed first thing in the morning, go to bed early, and fall asleep quickly. However, those people with a long body clock are night owls who love to sleep and stay up late and sleep through their alarm clocks. Inside the brain is the hypothalamus, which signals when it is time for the body to go to sleep.



BODY CLOCK

The amount of sleep required varies from person to person. Everyone has a personal body clock that lets them know how much sleep they need. Some people's body clocks are so precise that they wake up at the same time each day. Research shows that adults sleep anywhere between five and 11 hours a night, with the average being 7.75 hours.